

An Impassable Road to Glory

Loss, Displacement, and Social Transmission

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Motivation

- Most protracted global conflicts involve two elements: **disputed control over territory** and **population displacement**.
- Examples include 20th century Germany, the Nigerian Civil War, Ukraine, and Israel/Palestine.
- Over half of the world's countries have lost territory since 1816.
- Global IDP population exceeds 75 million; over 40 million people are internationally displaced.

Core implication

These losses are assumed to have a large effect on domestic politics, but the micro-level political mechanism is opaque.

Empirical target

Armenia after the 2020 Nagorno-Karabakh war provides a setting where loss, displacement, and political mobilization coincide.

- Study the effect of individual attitudes and narratives of loss on political participation in the context of the Nagorno-Karabakh conflict.
- Pre-registered identification strategy uses exogenous variation in expected exposure to displaced populations.
- Original measurement strategy captures social-network exposure and open-ended narratives of loss.

Main finding

People who care more about past losses show **increased anti-government participation** and reduced value on **clientelism**, driven by **narratives of victimization**.

Research Questions

Primary Question

How do individual attitudes and beliefs regarding past losses shape patterns of political participation?

- How are **protest participation** and **candidate preferences** affected by the relative value attached to lost territory?
- How do attributions of historical responsibility for losses shape political behavior?

Design problem

Elite narratives, personal connections, economic judgments, and community effects all matter, but each may be endogenous to individual choice.

Solution

Leverage an event that creates exogenous variation in the strength of individual connections to losses through social contacts.

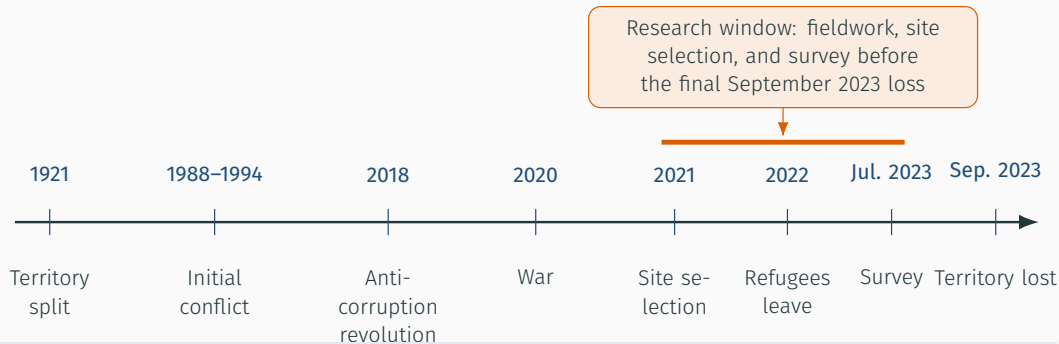
Affective response to territorial loss

Reflecting on loss of territory is associated with powerful aversive emotions:

1. ***Pain*** at the loss itself.
2. ***Anger*** at those who caused it.
3. ***Anxiety*** and fear over the nation's future.

- Increased willingness to engage in risky political action and emphasize symbolic over material gains.
- Disfavor the political establishment, which bears responsibility for the situation.
- But this depends on the *stories* people tell about loss.

Historical Timeline



Research context

Protests in 2018 brought Civil Contract to power; the 2020 war displaced people from Nagorno-Karabakh and generated mass protest over territorial losses.

Survey and fieldwork

- 1,166 local respondents in 38 communities in Southern Armenia near Yerevan.
- Surveyed in June-July 2023.
- Ethnographic fieldwork and elite interviews in all communities in Summer 2022.

Measure

1. Aggregate social-network structure.
2. Open-ended narratives of loss.
3. Loss importance: willingness to sacrifice own welfare.

Outcomes

Informal

Protest risk tolerance

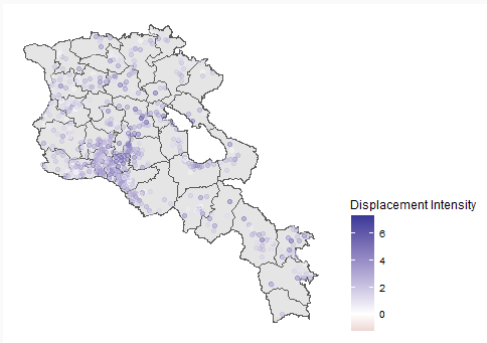
Formal participation

Incumbent voting

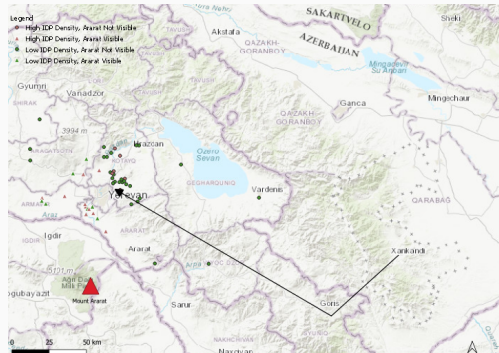
Cleavage formation

Symbolic compliance vs. clientelism

Research sites



Post-2020 displacement intensity



Study communities by Ararat visibility and refugee proportion

Key source of variation

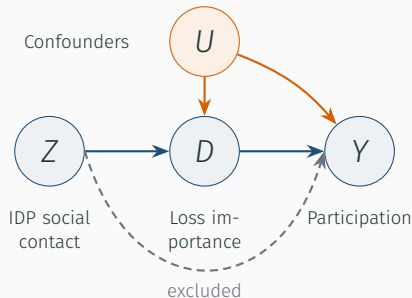
Settlement patterns after the 2020 war generate variation in expected social contact with IDPs across otherwise comparable communities.

Identification

- Estimate the causal effect of the relative importance individuals attach to lost territory on participation.
- Attitudes and salience are likely endogenous to political alignment.
- Leverage expected exposure to IDPs from Nagorno-Karabakh as a source of variation in loss salience and importance.

Estimand

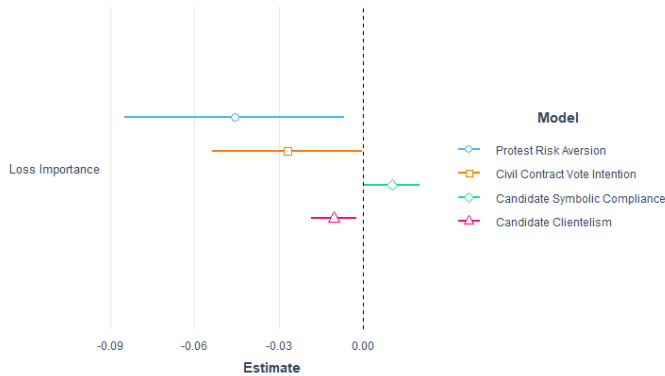
$$LATE_i^{loss} = \frac{\mathbb{E}[Y_i | Z_i = 1] - \mathbb{E}[Y_i | Z_i = 0]}{\mathbb{E}[D_i | Z_i = 1] - \mathbb{E}[D_i | Z_i = 0]}$$



Core assumptions

Monotonicity, exclusion restriction, and no unmeasured confounding with instrument.

Main effects: Loss Importance



Substantive pattern

Higher loss importance is associated with:

- lower protest risk aversion;
- lower incumbent vote intention;
- lower valuation of clientelism;
- greater symbolic compliance.

Popular Narratives of Loss

Domestic

We lost Artsakh [Nagorno-Karabakh]. The politicians did not keep our victory ... It is a part of our body and it hurts deeply.

Foreign

It was at the hands of the superpowers, now we have to be strong to get our territories back ...

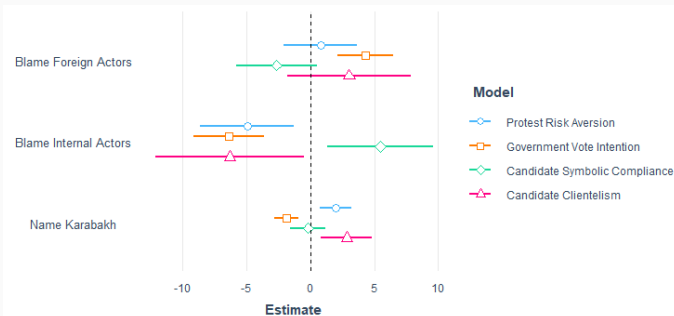
Historical

The [1921 treaty of] Kars was the problem ... the Russians' 11th army and Lenin betrayed us.

Analytic role

The empirical question is not only whether loss matters, but which narrative of responsibility gives loss political direction.

Narrative Effects



Interpretation

Narratives of blame are not interchangeable.

- Internal blame aligns with lower incumbent support and lower clientelist candidate preference.
- Foreign blame moves behavior in a different direction.
- Naming Karabakh shifts attention to the recent territorial loss.

1. First causal estimation of the impact of holding irredentist attitudes on political participation.
2. Individual concern for lost territory is associated with risk taking behavior.
3. Differing narratives of loss are associated with radically different patterns of behavior.

Broader implication

Displaced populations can shape local attitudes beyond intergroup hostility by making loss socially salient and narratively interpretable.

Political consequence

The effect is potentially destabilizing both domestically and internationally.

Thank you!

Please send any questions by email to pjc504@nyu.edu